

Instagram-a-licious

When top-model agent Matthew Anderson purchased his first home in Melbourne's Collingwood in 2004, it was not nearly in vogue. Collingwood was then a suburb of factories and ruffians, with a proud blue-collar heart, on the lip of the CBD; a melting pot of all walks of life. Anderson bought close enough to the main drag of Smith Street to hear the racket at the iconic Grace Darling Hotel, where not even the heft of its bluestone facade could dim the riffs of indie bands every night. Friendly locals from the council housing towers smoked rollies on sagging terrace stoops.

Now, Collingwood is one of Melbourne's most exclusive suburbs. It hosts some of the city's finest, award-winning restaurants; it's the crux of the ethically grown, cold-drip espresso movement, and the comeback of beatnik barbershops. The suburb's facelift is enough to make the old-timers propped at the Grace Darling bar, bleeding the Magpies' white and black, choke on their VB beer.

On Anderson's books, at Chadwick Models, are Australian supermodel Andreja Pejic and Victoria's Secret runway darling Jessica Hart. Anderson clearly has an eye for the next big thing, as much for bricks and mortar as for a beautiful face. But when he did a deal to secure a one-bedroom period cottage in Collingwood, most were convinced he'd made the wrong decision.

Anderson's conveyancing lawyer expressed sympathy instead of congratulations when he signed the contract. He recalls, of the decision to buy:

When I first moved into Collingwood, the bulk of feedback I got was how dodgy the area was going to be. I never really felt that, though; I liked it. I liked how Smith Street was just full of 'real' shops – mum-and-dad sandwich bars, and places to get your keys cut. I never felt unsafe, and all the immediate neighbours I had were the most neighbourly people I'd ever encountered.